



Q What do I need to think about when choosing child care?

Choosing a person or day-care center to entrust with the care of your baby is a hugely important decision, and one that you will want to consider carefully. Think about your priorities, which things you consider important and what you want for your baby, and look for child care that meets these requirements.

Personal choice

Talking to other parents can be useful, but keep in mind that the right child care for one family may not work for another. So while getting personal recommendations can be invaluable, you may have very different views. For example, while one family may think the social setting of a day-care center is advantageous, you may prefer your child to be in a more homey environment. Try to visit a few different types of settings rather than ruling anything out too early on. When you

visit, watch how caregivers interact with your child and other children. Are they responsive and caring, is the environment clean and welcoming, are there plenty of planned activities and toys for the children, and is there dedicated down time? Do the children seem happy and relaxed, and is there outside space? Ask to see copies of any policies, procedures, or certificates—any reputable caregivers will be happy to share these. Consider speaking to some parents who currently have their child at the setting.

DIFFERENT CHILD-CARE OPTIONS

Here is some information on different settings and options for child care. The logistics and prices vary so it is a good idea to do as much research as possible so that you make the right decision.



Day-care center

The setup: usually privately run, a day-care center offers all-day child care for young babies through to four to five years old. Staff is trained in child development, first aid, and CPR, and there are strict guidelines on ratios of staff to children. Babies and toddlers should have separate areas or rooms where the facilities are appropriate for their age.



What to think about: your baby should get plenty of stimulation, and will have lots of other children to socialize with. One-on-one time may be rare. The cost can be high, the opening hours are set, and there may be times when it is closed. There will be an illness policy, so you will need a backup plan if your child is sick.



Home care-center

The setup: also called licensed child-care homes, these should be licensed with the state and be background checked. Rules are different in every state, but there are limits on the number of children that can be taken care of at a time. It's usually only a handful of children under five, with only one or two children under age one or two.



What to think about: your child will be in a home environment, will have a few other children to socialize with, and will receive plenty of attention. In-home day-care staff take care of children for an extended period of time, which gives continuity, and your child is likely to form a close bond with them. If your licensed child-care worker is sick, you will need to have a backup plan.



Nanny

The setup: a qualified individual who will take care of your child in your own home.



What to think about: your child will receive one-on-one care in her own home. Nannies can become a significant part of the family and can stay in touch for years to come. They may be more flexible, occasionally being available for babysitting or weekend care. Nannying is usually the most expensive child-care option, and you are the nanny's employer so will need to pay tax, Social Security and vacation pay. Some nannies ask for extras such as the use of a car. Your child will be on her own unless your nanny meets up with other nannies and their charges.

